

Final paper assignment (Due Tuesday, May 20th by 11:59PM)

Please answer the question in 6-7 double-spaced pages of your own original writing. I expect you to engage meaningfully with **AT LEAST THREE** books/articles/items on the syllabus. (Please do not submit an off-the-cuff ramble with token citations sprinkled in to keep up appearances!)

Please include a bibliography and standard references in parentheses or footnotes. APA, MLA, and Chicago style are all acceptable. Be sure to cite authors appropriately and use quotation marks or block quotes if you are using authors' language. Please do not ask AI chatbots to do your writing for you. **The submission of AI-generated answers violates this class's academic honesty policies.** AI bots also plagiarize text, invent spurious citations, and say factually incorrect things. I am asking you for your own creative, original thought on a key topic from this course. AI is not capable of thinking creatively or originally, so don't waste your time with it.

I will ask you to present a 2-3 minute summary of your paper topic in class on May 13th. This will be graded as part of the assignment (5 points), so you need to present something, even if it is a brief description of a work-in-progress. The point is to get you thinking about your paper topic, organization, etc. early so that you produce a better final product.

Please submit your final papers via Blackboard by 11:59PM on May 20th. Papers submitted late will be graded down 2 points per day until they are turned in.

If you have questions or require an extension, please ask so that I can help you.

Questions (answer ONE of the following in 6-7 pages, double-spaced):

Option 1: deep dive into a specific environmental justice issue

Pick an environmental justice issue from our readings or class discussions. You may discuss a general problem like climate change or a specific case such as the Flint water crisis. Explain in detail how injustice manifests in this particular issue or case. Who suffers injustice, and what is the nature of that injustice? What is the cause of injustice? (You may discuss structural causes like racial capitalism or colonialism, or specific government policies, being mindful that bad policies often have structural roots.) What specific remedies would be necessary to produce justice in your particular issue or case? Your proposed remedies should address the root of the problem. You should also briefly discuss the feasibility of your proposed solution, since addressing root causes can be quite difficult and there are often open questions about how much we can accomplish – and on what time scale. Please think your answer through and explain it in sufficient detail. You have 6-7 pages to tell me about the injustice, its causes, and how you propose to create justice for those affected.

Option 2: structural vs. individual causes of justice and injustice

Political and economic structures constrain the behavior of the actors in a system. This sometimes has unfortunate consequences, when structure selects for bad behavior or bad outcomes. As Kenneth Waltz observes, “So long as one leaves the structure unaffected it is not possible for changes in the intentions and the actions of particular actors to produce desirable outcomes or to avoid undesirable ones.”[1] To what extent is environmental injustice a structural problem, a product of capitalism, colonialism, racism, etc.? Do we need structural changes in order to achieve environmental justice? Or can justice be achieved by working at the individual level – putting younger people in charge of climate policy, electing “just leaders,” educating people in better ways of living, or perhaps introducing new policies or technologies to the existing system?

In answering this question, you will need to engage with at least one form of structure discussed in the readings. You may consider capitalism (as discussed by Saitō), colonialism (as discussed by Gilio-Whitaker), cis/hetero-patriarchy and racism (discussed in many of the readings), or anything else you identify as a system or structure. (If unsure, please ask me whether the thing you are thinking about is a structure or not.) You will also need to discuss potential remedies for environmental justice, based on whether you think the problem is structural or individual in nature. How would we change the structure – or how would we change individual people, governments, policies, or corporations to produce more just results? It may be helpful to focus on a particular aspect of justice, or a particular environmental injustice discussed in the readings, to ground your answer.

[1] Kenneth N. Waltz, *Theory of International Politics* (Reading, Massachusetts: Addison Wesley, 1979), 108.